reaching reforms in the space sector", explicitly aimed at enabling private-sector participation across the full range of space activities.

The reforms created a route for private companies to design, build, own and operate rockets, satellites, ground systems and launch infrastructure, subject to authorisation.

"It was a big relief," recalls Ahmed, who co-founded Pixxel with Kshitij Khandelwal at BITS Pilani in 2019. "We could all build a satellite. But before this announcement came, launching a satellite for a private company was basically illegal."

Isro and IN-SPACe didn't respond to email requests for comments.

The 2023 Indian Space Policy formalised the new architecture. An Indian company could now design its own rocket or satellite, own the technology, and take it to market. This was followed by the easing of foreign direct investment (FDI) rules in 2024, making way for up to 100% FDI into Indian spacetech.

These changes released pent-up ambition. Government data showed the number of active space start-ups jumped to around 440 by 2026 from a few dozen in 2020, as they spread across almost every layer of the space economy.

Skyroot, Agnikul, and Pune's Astrophel Aerospace began building rockets, the vehicles that carry satellites into orbit. Hyderabad-based Abyom SpaceTech & Defence started building reusable rockets, advanced space infrastructure and dual-use technologies. Bellatrix went after propulsion, the systems that move spacecraft once they get there. Dhruva Space built satellite platforms and the ground infrastructure needed to receive and process what comes back.

Pixxel built hyperspectral imaging sensors and EON Space Labs, also from Hyderabad, made electro-optical payloads—the cameras and instruments that collect information from space; Bengaluru-based GalaxEye Space combined optical and radar sensing into one. Digantara started with space domain awareness, tracking satellites, debris, and other objects already crowding the orbit.

Together, they form a chain across the space economy, with each layer enabling the next. "Space is the next frontier," says Jainul Abedin, Founder & CEO of Abyom. "Whether we realise it or not, our everyday lives are becoming increasingly dependent on space. A farmer doesn't necessarily need to know that a satellite is behind the weather data he uses before sowing, the crop insurance he accesses, or the digital maps that help him navigate. But the infrastructure enabling many of these services increasingly begins in space."

Today, India operates just over 50 satellites, spread across communication, navigation, earth observa-



"As a private company, we were still unproven, but once they saw that we were coming from India, and had retired Isro scientists as advisors, we were taken seriously"

AWAIS AHMED
CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, PIXXEL

WHERE THE MONEY IS GOING

PE-VC investments in spacetech companies by segment



NOTE FIGURES FROM 2019-2026 YTD
SOURCE VENTURE INTELLIGENCE